INTRODUCTION · REINVENTING MANAGEMENT

Two fundamentally different philosophies of management.

Same people. Same resources. Completely different organisations.

DIMENSION	EXTRACTIVE MANAGEMENT	REGENERATIVE MANAGEMENT
VIEW OF PEOPLE	Human Resources — to be allocated and utilised	Human Sources — to be partnered with and developed
CORE QUESTION	How do we get more from what we have?	What can we co-create with people as partners?
CONTROL MODE	Compliance through surveillance and pressure	Trust through developed capability and purpose
TIME HORIZON	This quarter. This year. This metric.	This decade. This legacy. This generation.
CULTURE	People perform when watched	People perform because they believe
PRODUCES	BUSYness — motion without meaning	High Performance — meaning that compounds

> "The shift from extractive to regenerative is not a values exercise. It is the most consequential structural decision a leader makes."

Kill BUSYness, Get High Performance · Manoj Onkar

CHAPTER 5

Reflection

"BUSYness is not the enemy. It is the disguise."

What is your BUSYness hiding?

BUSYness is not the problem.

That may seem strange in a book called Kill BUSYness. But it is true. BUSYness is the solution. A remarkably effective, compulsively maintained, socially approved solution to a problem most leaders never quite articulate — the discomfort of not knowing.

Not knowing the real game. Not knowing whether your clients value you or merely tolerate you. Not knowing whether your strategy is a real strategy or a plan dressed up in strategic language. Not

knowing whether your best people are truly committed or planning their exits. Not knowing whether what you believe about your market is still true — or whether you have been operating inside a mental model that the market stopped matching two years ago.

These are difficult things not to know. And BUSYness fills the space where that discomfort would live. It fills time so completely, so relentlessly, so legitimately, that the deeper work never has to happen. The difficult questions never have to be asked. The honest conversations never have to be had. The mirror never has to be faced.

McKinsey's research on how CEOs actually spend their time captures the scale of this problem. During periods of operational pressure — which for most organisations means most of the time — CEOs report spending less than one hour per week on long-term strategy. Not because these CEOs are poor leaders. Because BUSYness has claimed the time that the deeper work requires, and claimed it so completely and so legitimately that the loss feels like unavoidable circumstance rather than a choice with consequences.

As Peter Senge said: learning happens in the moments of reflection. If you and your organisation are too BUSY to reflect, then…

In our leadership workshops, we say: *most good conversations are slow conversations*. The insight that changes everything does not arrive in a thirty-minute stand-up. It arrives in the space you create for it.

When we work with organisations on long-term transformation, we generally label their current business as Version 1.0 and the desired future business as Version 2.0. The 1.0 business can consume 48 hours a day if you let it. The 2.0 business will not happen — will not go beyond a good idea — unless you create dedicated time for it. We encourage clients to progressively invest more time in building Version 2.0, ultimately working toward two to three full days a week dedicated to building the future.

Key Finding	Source
One day/week of reflection time generated more strategic value than the meetings it replaced	*Harvard Business Review, 2017*
53% of workers spend the majority of their time on busywork	*Asana State of Work Innovation Report 2024*
Deep innovation requires protected reflection time; reactive organisations cannot sense emerging futures	*Otto Scharmer, "Theory U," MIT Sloan*
CEOs spend <1 hour/week on long-term strategy during operational pressure	*McKinsey CEO survey data*

Seven Things BUSYness Hides

Truth One: Absence of Real Data.

Your dashboards show what is happening inside the organisation. They do not show what your clients think of you when you are not in the room. The organisation that does not gather this data is not data-driven. It is assumption-driven. And assumptions, held long

enough without examination, become beliefs. And beliefs, defended fiercely enough, become the walls of the box the organisation cannot see its way out of.

Truth Two: Absence of Real Thinking.

Processing is fast. Thinking is slow — and protected by nothing in a BUSY organisation. Real thinking, the kind that produces real insight and real strategy, requires time that BUSYness has already spent. It requires the willingness to sit with a problem long enough that the obvious answers exhaust themselves and the real answer begins to emerge.

More than half the working week, in more than half of organisations, is consumed by activity that never required thinking at all. What is left for the thinking that actually matters — the kind that is slow, protected, and uncomfortable — is the residue. And in a BUSY organisation, that time does not exist. A BUSY organisation does not think. It reacts.

Truth Three: Absence of Reflection.

There is a difference between review and reflection that most organisations do not honour. Review asks: what happened? Reflection asks: what does it mean? Review produces reports. Reflection produces wisdom. And wisdom cannot be produced by any amount of review. It can only be produced by deliberate, protected, unhurried stillness.

Harvard Business Review's research on this is simple and startling. When executives reclaimed just one day per week for focused,

uninterrupted thinking, they reported significant improvements not just in their own clarity but in productivity, communication, and teamwork across their organisations. The reflection time created more strategic value than the meetings it replaced.

Dr. Otto Scharmer described the capacity to observe not just what is happening, but the deeper patterns beneath the surface. That capacity is built in silence. Not in meetings.

Truth Four: Absence of Real Relationships.

Business is conducted in transactions. High-Performance is built in relationships. A relationship is a depth of understanding of the other person's reality — their pressures, their genuine needs, their long-term objectives. The organisation that is too busy for this depth of relationship knows its clients transactionally. It knows what they buy, what they pay, and whether they renew. It does not know what keeps them awake at three in the morning. That distinction — partner versus service provider — is not a relationship category. It is a strategic position.

Truth Five: Absence of Aligned Purpose.

The CEO's purpose is clear at the top. And invisible at the frontline. Purpose requires not announcement but transmission — patient, repeated, personally modelled, consistently demonstrated transmission of what this organisation exists to do and why it matters. A BUSY organisation has no time for this.

Truth Six: Absence of Fresh Eyes.

Every organisation develops assumptions about how the market works, what customers want, and what the rules of the game are. These assumptions were probably accurate when they were formed. They may no longer be. The organisation that is too busy to challenge its own assumptions is operating in its mental model of the market — not the actual market.

We have already seen the starkest example of this in Chapter 3: Kodak's own engineers built the world's first digital camera in 1975 and leadership suppressed it. The fresh eyes were there. BUSYness — the relentless pressure of protecting the existing business — kept the truth from ever becoming a decision.

Truth Seven: Absence of Real Strategy.

This is the deepest thing BUSYness hides. Most organisations do not have a real strategy. They have a plan. And beneath even the plan, something more fundamental is missing: the homework. Real strategy requires truly understanding the industry, the client, the competition, with the depth and freshness of someone seeing it for the first time. This homework takes time. And a BUSY organisation cannot do it.

Jeff Bezos required every significant initiative at Amazon to be preceded by a Working Backwards document — a press release and FAQ written as if the product already existed and had succeeded. Teams were forced to do the thinking before the building. The organisations that do the homework produce strategies that navigate by map. The ones that skip it navigate by memory. And

memory, in a market that keeps moving, is an increasingly unreliable guide.

The Strategic Mirror: Two Questions

If you want to know whether your organisation has done the real homework behind the strategy, these two questions will tell you.

Question One: Do you see your industry differently from your competitors? Not better-resourced. Not more experienced. *Differently*. Do you understand something about where this industry is going that your competition has not yet seen? If the honest answer is no, your strategy is a plan to compete on the same terms as everyone else. And competing on the same terms produces average results at best, and irrelevance at worst.

Question Two: Are you a partner to your clients, or a service provider? This is not a relationship question. The distinction matters — it is a question of knowledge depth, not relationship warmth. A partner knows the client's business as deeply as the client knows it. A partner understands the client's long-term objectives — not just the brief, but the real ones that will determine whether the client wins or loses over the next decade. Knowledge of that depth is not built in BUSY organisations.

Exercises — Chapter 5: Reflection

A BUSY organisation reacts. A serious organisation reflects. These exercises are designed to reopen the space in which wisdom and strategic freshness can actually emerge.

Exercise 1: Protected Thinking

— When did you last spend two uninterrupted hours thinking about the fundamental direction of your organisation? Not reviewing. Not planning. Thinking deeply, slowly, without an agenda.

— What did you learn from that time? If you haven't done this recently, what has been making decisions in its place: speed, habit, fear, or exhaustion?

— Block two ninety-minute thinking sessions in the next fourteen days. Protect them like a board meeting. What question will you bring to each?

Exercise 2: Reality Beyond the Room

Answer the Seven Questions without softening. The discomfort in any answer has a name — it is the thing your BUSYness has been hiding.

— **Data:** When did you last gather deep, unfiltered intelligence about what your clients truly think of your organisation?

— **Thinking:** When did you last give yourself uninterrupted time — hours, not minutes — to think about the fundamental direction of your organisation?

— **Reflection:** When did you last step back from daily operations and examine the deeper patterns in how your organisation is performing, and why?

— **Relationships:** Do you know the long-term objectives of your top five clients — not their immediate needs, their genuine long-term ambitions?

— **Purpose:** If you asked ten people at different levels of your organisation what your purpose is, would the answers be consistent, specific, and meaningful?

— **Fresh Eyes:** When did you last examine your industry, your business model, and your competitive position as if you were seeing them for the first time?

— **Strategy:** Can you state your Where to Play and How to Win in two sentences, and point to specific decisions made this month that reflect those choices?

Exercise 3: The Reflection Discipline

— What recurring pattern in performance have you still not interpreted clearly? Name it.

— Are your people living a purpose, or merely doing a job? How do you know?

— What one truth has your BUSYness been hiding that, if faced fully today, would change what you do next week?

The Mirror Question

Sit with your organisation. Not in it. With it. What is really going on — not what the reports say, but what you would see if you looked without defence?

Write the sentence you least want to write.

If there is no protected space for reflection, BUSYness will always do the thinking for you — and BUSYness is not a strategic thinker. It is a reactive one. The truth your BUSYness has been hiding is also your greatest opportunity. Once seen clearly and honestly, it becomes the

most powerful starting point available to you. Not a crisis. A starting point.

Chapter 6 moves from what BUSYness is hiding to what ownership actually means — in daily behaviour, in the way commitments are made and kept, and in the most direct test of your culture: does this organisation depend on follow-up and reminders to get things done?